

Notes of International Politics

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International Politics

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Session 2, February 16: Grand theories of war and peace

*** (Bueno de Mesquita, 2013)[Chapter 5]

- (Levy, n.d.)
- (Lake, 2011)
- (Lake et al., 2021)
- (Milner et al., 2023)
- (“One World, Rival Theories”, n.d.)

1 Bueno de Mesquita, 2013

- War is generally inefficient compared to reaching a negotiated settlement.
- The risks of war may be exacerbated by uncertainty, making credible commitments, or winner-takes-all situation.
- Some important neorealist hypotheses about international peace and stability do not flow logically from that theory's core assumptions. Other important neorealist hypotheses are falsified by the empirical record.
- The link between power transition theory's assumptions and hypotheses is more clear-cut than is true in the case of neorealism.
- Some core power transition hypotheses follow from the theory's logic and are supported by evidence; others either do not follow logically or are not borne out by evidence.
- The power transition theory outperforms neorealism when it comes to offering a structural explanation for war, but its weaknesses point to a need to reconsider its approach to domestic politics.

Consider that estimates of war-related deaths per year in the past 100 years vary approximately from 1 to 2 million.

1.1 War and Uncertainty

The ex ante problems that seem to lead to war can be reduced to three main factors: (1) uncertainty, (2) commitment problems, and (3) indivisibility of issues (Fearon 1995; Slantchev 2003).

1 Absence of **credible commitments** between the sides.

1.1 The inability to **commit to negotiating** patiently rather than seizing the first-strike advantage exacerbates the risk of war (Powell 1999; Slantchev 2003)

1.2 The idea is that the Israelis give up some land in exchange for a guarantee of peace. An alternative formulation reverses the sequence of concessions—the Palestinian Authority disarms its factions that engage in violence against Israel in return for land concessions. Either approach is likely to fail because each induces a fundamental commitment problem.

Land for peace suffers from a time inconsistency problem.

2 Dispute is about an **indivisible objective** → No settlement can produce a compromise in this case of indivisibility, and so there is a severe risk of war. If control over all the land currently held by Israel is truly its irreducible objective, then the land is viewed as indivisible by Hamas.

3 This **uncertainty about the true probability of victory** or defeat might arise out of private (secret) information about the morale of their fighting forces, about knowledge of outside help, about the quality of their war plans, or a host of other possible factors.

1.2 Realist Theory

Neorealist theorists believe that the distribution of power in the international system is a major factor in determining whether international affairs are stable or unstable. Stability refers to circumstances in which the sovereignty of key states is preserved (Gulick 1955). Instability refers to changes in the composition of the international system, especially changes involving the disappearance or emergence of “key” states following large wars. Key states are those whose assistance might be necessary to counteract a threat from a rival coalition of states.

In addressing war and instability, neorealist theories start with the following four assumptions:

1. International politics is anarchic. $\Rightarrow$ there is no supranational authority that can enforce agreements between states.
2. States, as rational unitary entities, are the central actors in international politics. $\Rightarrow$ domestic politics does not influence international politics.
3. States seek to maximize their security above all else and consider other factors only after security is assured. $\Rightarrow$ states are not willing to trade away their security for other benefits. Other possible goals, such as wealth, are pursued only after security has been assured (Waltz 1979, 126).
4. States seek to increase their power as long as doing so does not place their security at risk. $\Rightarrow$ states accept being weaker than they might otherwise be if the pursuit of greater power would place their security at risk.

Most important neorealist conclusions

1. Bipolar systems are more stable than multipolar systems.
2. States engage in balancing behavior so that power becomes more or less equally divided among states over time.
3. States mimic, or echo, one another’s behavior.

2 How Well Does Neorealism Do in Explaining War and Instability?

2.1 Bipolarity and Stability

The argument that bipolar structures are more stable than multipolar ones is built on the claim that there is more uncertainty in a multipolar system than in a bipolar one.

Bipolarity is thought to alleviate two of the conditions we have discussed that are thought to increase the risk of war: uncertainty and commitment problems.

There are several problems with the argument that because bipolar systems encompass less uncertainty than multipolar systems they yield greater stability. This argument is not implied logically by the four key assumptions of neorealism.

1. First, variation in the response to uncertainty violates the unitary rational actor assumption, which contends that important choices in international politics are driven by structural factors, not by considerations internal to the state.

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2. Second, if different decision makers respond to uncertainty in different ways, then there is no reason to expect any empirical relationship between bipolarity and stability at all.
 3. Third, if leaders differ in how they respond to uncertainty, then the third hypothesis (that states mimic one another) does not hold up.
 4. taking the neorealist assumptions into account, we can show that it is logically true that more distributions of power are stable in a multipolar world than in a bipolar world.

2.2 Bipolarity and Stability 2

Stability in a multipolar world is not limited to the situation of exact power equality. This is in marked contrast to the bipolar world, in which stability can be achieved only through a perfectly equal division of resources between the two blocs.

Thus, it appears that the first neorealist hypothesis, that bipolarity promotes stability and multipolarity promotes instability, is logically flawed given the assumptions of the theory.

Further, it seems that a true balance of power is essential for stability in a bipolar world, but not in a multipolar one, contradicting the second hypothesis. A vast array of power distributions can produce stability. In a multipolar environment, an exact balance of power is irrelevant.

Either the balance of power does not matter in multipolarity or the term is defined to mean any system in which each actor is essential. In the latter case, so many systems qualify as a balance-of-power system that the concept doesn't have much meaning in our search for answers.

2.3 History and Neorealist Empirical Claims

1. The international system was multipolar in structure from 1648 until the defeat of Germany in 1945. Thus, between 1648 and 1945 there were many major powers with no one or two predominating. $\Rightarrow$ The bipolar system began in 1945 and lasted until about 1989.
2. Using Jack Levy's (1983) classification of great powers since 1492, we can determine whether the longevity of the bipolar system was comparatively long or short. $\Rightarrow$
3. Another way to evaluate the stability of the international system is to examine the frequency of wars among the most influential states in the world
4. The UN Security Council (UNSC), then, by institutionalizing a multipolar decision-making structure, has provided a counterweight to bipolarity. This too may be an explanation for the long peace.
5. The average interval between general wars is thirty-four years; the longest interval is ninety-nine years, much longer than the so-called long peace. It appears, then, that the bipolar, long peace cannot be considered unusually long after all and that bipolarity is not a superior treatment for the disease of major power war than is multipolarity.

2.4 Historical Record of Essential and Inessential States

An essential state is any state that can join a losing coalition and, by dint of its membership and the power it can bring to bear, turn that coalition into a blocking coalition or a winning coalition.

Inessential states are states that are unable to turn even one losing alliance into a winning or blocking coalition.

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1. Essential states never become inessential.
 2. Essential states are never eliminated from the international system.
 3. Inessential states never become essential states.
 4. Inessential states are always eliminated from the international system.

Each of these propositions is historically false.

2.5 Balance of Power and Neorealism

Perhaps the most common claim among neorealist theorists is that war occurs only when both sides believe that their chance of winning is greater than 50 percent. This is a partial statement of what has come to be known as the balance-of-power theory. It invokes the idea that war is the product of mutual optimism by rival states, meaning that they overestimate their chances of victory

If the neorealist hypothesis were correct, we should observe no wars initiated by the weaker side. The evidence fails to support the hypothesis.

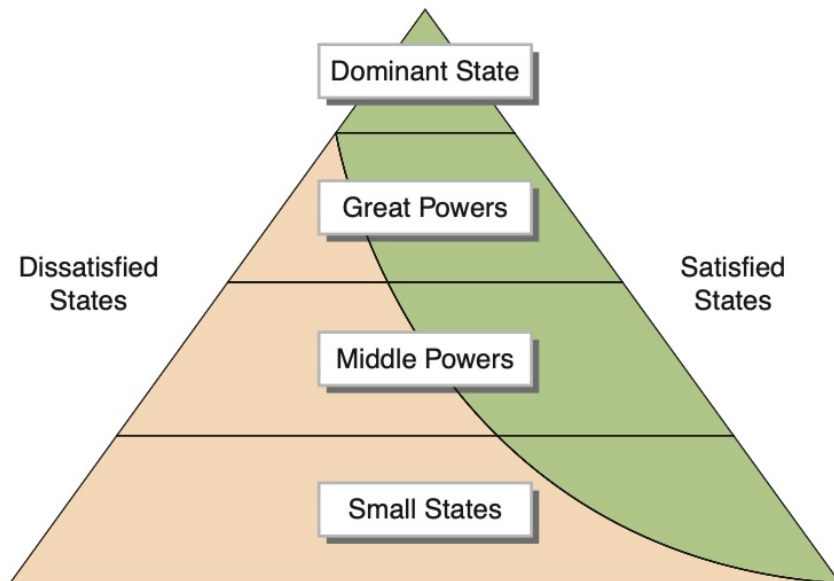
3 The Power Transition

Building on the work of Edward Carr (1939, 1945) and Organski (1958) constructed what was perhaps the first challenge to realism that was neither idealistic nor normative.

- The international system is not anarchic.
- There is only one dominant state at any given time.
- Rather than wishing to maximize security or power, nations are interested in maximizing their **control over the rules and customs that govern international interactions** so that they can define the status quo according to their interests.

Bretton Woods Agreement $\Rightarrow$ These agreements still maintain a rule-based and normative influence on the trading practices of their members.

Dissatisfaction $\Rightarrow$ it is the more powerful dissatisfied states that represent the biggest threat to international peace and stability.

FIGURE 5.5**The Power Transition Power Triangle**

Power transition theory divides the world into two coalitions: (1) satisfied states and (2) dissatisfied states. The stronger a state is, the more likely that it is satisfied with the organization of the international system and the status quo that reflects that system's rules. Weaker states are more likely to be dissatisfied.

Source: Organski (1958).

Figura 1

3.1 Dissatisfaction, the Status Quo, and War

Conflict arises when a dissatisfied state grows strong enough to challenge the authority of the hegemon. Because such a challenge concerns the very way in which international affairs are conducted, the ensuing conflict is fierce and costly.

This time period during which the challenger roughly comes to equal and then surpass the dominant state in power is known as the power transition. It is the time when the threat of a major war is hypothesized to be at its peak. **Contrary to the balance-of-power perspective**, power transition and hegemonic stability theorists believe that major wars are most likely to occur when the power of the opposed states is about equal.

According to these theorists, a balance of power promotes war. They maintain that system-transforming wars—that is, wars that lead to a new power hierarchy and to new rules and norms—will occur only when the power of a challenger and the dominant state are about equal and the power of the challenger is increasing faster than that of the dominant state. These claims have been extended and shown to have **empirical strength** at the regional as well as the global level, so that regional hegemons apparently face the same pressures and the same sources of war as their global counterparts.

Threatening balance of power emerges as a result of differing rates of internal growth between a dominant state and a challenger state. These theories still give little attention to domestic politics per se, but they do recognize that internal factors shape rates of growth.

Power transition theory leads to the hypothesis that system-transforming, high-cost wars are

especially likely when a dissatisfied challenger state achieves approximate power parity with the dominant, status quo-defending state.

Kim and Morrow have shown that the distribution of power at which the rivals will fight depends on their willingness to take the risks of waiting. The longer the challenger waits to attack, the higher is its probability of victory. This is true because the challenger's power is growing faster than the dominant state's power. Thus, the longer the challenger puts off a war, the greater will be the odds in its favor. However, the longer it waits, the longer it must endure the rules of international intercourse with which it is dissatisfied.

Kim and Morrow have shown that the interval during which the challenger is willing to fight expands as the expected costs of the war increase, as the challenger's dissatisfaction with the status quo increases, as the challenger's relative growth rate declines, and as the challenger becomes more risk acceptant.

How long the challenger and the dominant states will wait before fighting depends on their respective responses to risk, their relative rates of growth, the expected costs of the war, and their respective degrees of satisfaction with the status quo.

Differences in growth rates turn out not to be crucial empirically.

Power transitions per se cannot explain especially costly wars.

FIGURE 5.6 Power Transition Theory and the Likelihood of War

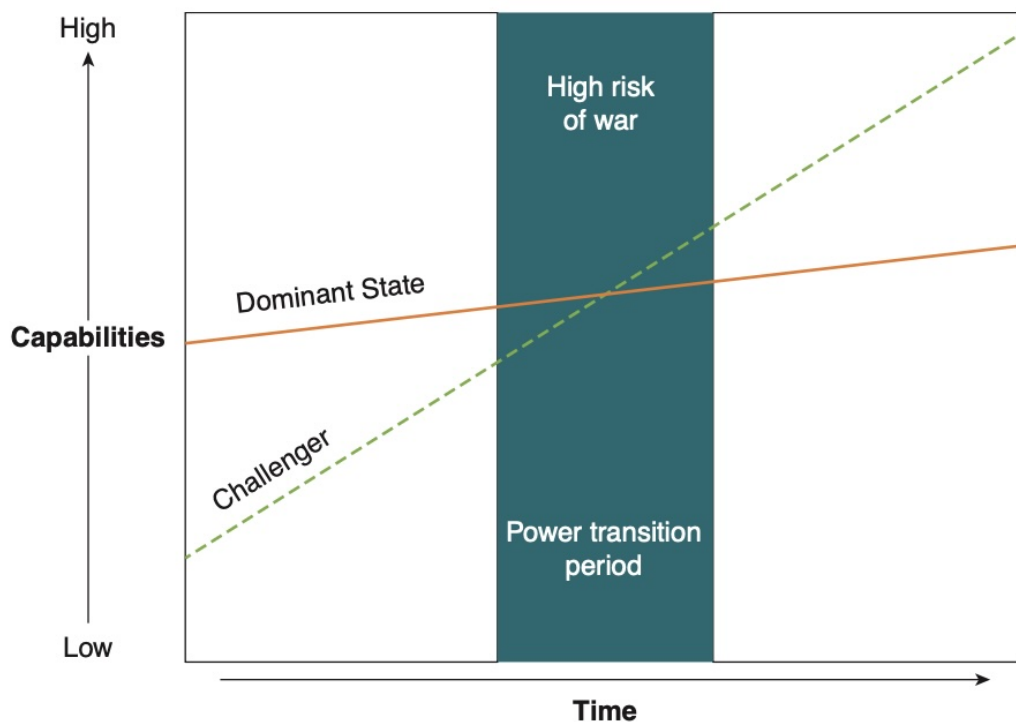


Figura 2

4 Levy, n.d.

This makes it hard to argue that human nature and related factors are causes of war. The point is that these factors are constants and cannot explain the variations in war and peace over time and space (Waltz 1959, Cashman 1993).

Why does war occur at some times rather than other times, between some states rather than other states, under some political leaders rather than others, in some historical and cultural contexts rather than others, and so on? This differs from still a third question: How do we explain the origins of a particular war? Most international relations scholars (and particularly those in North America) focus primarily on the second question, explaining variations in war and peace. They leave the question of why war occurs at all to philosophers and biologists and leave the question of why a particular war occurs to historians.

Although **anarchy** may provide one persuasive answer to the question of the permissive causes of war, it is generally treated as a structural constant and consequently it cannot account for variations in war and peace.

4.1 The Levels-of-Analysis Framework

Waltz (1959) classified the causes of war in terms of their origins in the individual, the nation-state, and the international system $\Rightarrow$ levels-of-analysis framework as an organizing device for the study of war.

In this sense the systemic level of analysis refers to explanations of patterns and outcomes in the international system; the dyadic level refers to explanations of the strategic interactions between two states; the national level refers to explanations of state foreign policy behavior; the organizational level refers to explanations of the behavior of organizations; and the individual level refers to explanations of the preferences, beliefs, or choices of individuals.

We cannot assume that correlations or causal connections at one level of analysis are necessarily valid at another level. It is conceivable, for example, that concentrations of power may promote peace at the dyadic level but war at the system level.

4.2 Systemic-Level Theories

The realist tradition has dominated the study of war since Thucydides and includes Machiavellians, Hobbesians, classical balance of power theorists, Waltzian neorealists, and hegemonic transition theorists. Although different realist theories often generate conflicting predictions, they share a core of common assumptions: the key actors in world politics are sovereign states that act rationally to advance their security, power, and wealth in a conflictual international system that lacks a legitimate governmental authority to regulate conflicts or enforce agreements.

- they use Prisoner's Dilemma and stag-hunt models
- The core proposition of realist theory is that the distribution of power, throughout the system or within a dyad, is the primary factor shaping international outcomes.

We should treat realism as a paradigm rather than as a theory, and focus instead on specific theories that generate more determinant, testable propositions.

4.2.1 Hegemonic Theory or Power Transition Theory

Hegemonic theory is a structural theory that incorporates power transition theory and hegemonic stability theory and that **downplays the importance of anarchy**.

Hegemons commonly arise and use their strength to create a set of political and economic structures and norms of behavior that enhance the stability of the system while advancing their own security. Differential rates of growth, the costs of imperial overextension, and the development of vested domestic interests lead to the rise and fall of hegemons, and the probability of a major war is greatest at the point when the declining leader is being overtaken by the rising challenger.

Power transition theorists disagree somewhat on the precise identity of hegemonic wars and the particular causal dynamics from which they arise.

4.2.2 Balance of Power Theory

Balance of power theory is more concerned with explaining national strategies, the formation of blocking coalitions, the avoidance of hegemony, and the stability of the system than the origins of wars, which are underdetermined.

There is a major debate, however, between classical realists, who argue that stability is further supported by the presence of a multipolar distribution of power and a “flexible” alliance system (Morgenthau 1967, Gulick 1955), and neorealists, who argue that bipolarity is more stable than multipolarity (Waltz 1979, Mearsheimer 1990).

Balance of power theory and power transition theory appear to be diametrically opposed; the former argues that hegemony never occurs and that concentrations of power are destabilizing, and the latter argues the opposite.

4.2.3 Realism and Liberalism

The relationship between economic interdependence and war is an old question that has attracted new attention in the past few years.

Liberal economic theory of war: Montesquieu [1777 (1748)] stated that “peace is the natural effect of trade,” and liberal economic theorists since Smith [1937 (1776)] and Ricardo [1977 (1817)] have argued that capitalist economic systems and the free exchange of goods in an international market economy are the best guarantors of peace.

Realist: they often argue that the effect of trade on war is small relative to that of military and diplomatic considerations. They also question the liberal assumption that trade is always more efficient than military coercion in expanding markets and investment opportunities and in promoting state wealth.

Whether the incentives for the gains from trade dominate the incentives for coercion or protection based on economic asymmetries, and whether the latter escalate to trade wars and militarized conflicts, are empirical questions that analysts have only recently begun to analyze systematically.

Historical and empirical evidence of trade between enemies

Although liberals and realists disagree on the effects of trade on war, **they appear to agree that trade and other forms of economic interchange between societies will cease or be drastically reduced once states are at war with each other**. Contrary to both liberal and realist expectations, however, **there are numerous historical cases of trade between**

enemies during wartime, and a preliminary quantitative study suggests that war frequently does little to depress the volume of trade between adversaries (Barbieri & Levy 1997).

Need to incorporate domestic variables into their hypotheses

States often hesitate to terminate trade with the enemy for fear that they will lose that trade to a third party, who may be a greater economic or military rival.

These omissions have led all but the most committed neorealists to conclude that **systemic-level theories are theoretically incomplete and empirically inadequate**, in that **they leave too much of the variation in the outbreak and expansion of war unexplained**.

4.3 Social-Level Theories

4.4 Individual-Level Theories

decision-making is characterized by “bounded rationality” **Assumptions:**

- (a) that external and internal structures and social forces are not translated directly into foreign policy choices;
- (b) that key decision-makers vary in their definitions of state interests, assessments of threats to those interests, and/or beliefs as to the optimum strategies to achieve those interests; and
- (c) that differences in the content of actors’ belief systems, in the psychological processes through which they acquire information and make judgments and decisions, and in their personalities and emotional states are important intervening variables in explaining observed variation in state behaviors with respect to issues of war and peace.

Prospect Theory one of the most recent attempts to apply a social-psychological model to international relations (Kahneman & Tversky (1979)).

Prospect theory assumes that people evaluate outcomes in terms of deviations from a reference point or aspiration level rather than in terms of net-asset levels.

This asymmetry of behavior with respect to gains and losses means that the way people frame their reference point in any given choice problem is critical.

4.5 General Trends

- shift away from the systemic level: dissatisfaction with the failure of structural systemic models to explain enough of the variance in war and peace. This shift has led to rising interest in both dyadic-level behavior and societal-level explanatory variables.
- Whatever the relationship between concentrations of military and economic capabilities at the systemic level, there is substantial evidence that at the dyadic level an equality of capabilities is significantly more likely to lead to war.
- In the past decade most international relations theorists have moved beyond their earlier preoccupation with explanations at a single level of analysis and debates about which level provides the most powerful explanations. They now give much more attention to interaction effects among variables at different levels in the processes leading to war

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